

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- A quiet day nationally - no big new policy or inspection story breaking in the last 24-48 hours. Today's actual developments are operational rather than headline-grabbing.
- DfE's latest update (published yesterday) revises free school meals guidance for no-recourse-to-public-funds families, publishes fresh high-needs pupil census data, and opens the 2027/28 high-needs place-change process for local authorities.
→ **For your school:** Worth flagging to FSM/pastoral leads now the autumn census recheck deadline has moved to 2 November.
- Locally: two Doncaster Catholic primaries' applications to convert to academy status and join St Francis Catholic MAT are among DfE's Yorkshire & Humber decisions due this month.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

8 Oct 2026 — DfE pupil premium quarter 2 payments for 2026/27 made to academies open at 1 April 2026.

16 Oct 2026 — Midday deadline for Sheffield secondary school applications for September 2027 entry (national deadline 31 Oct).

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

2 Nov 2026 — Extended deadline for schools to complete autumn census free school meals eligibility rechecks.

■ NATIONAL: DfE'S OCTOBER UPDATE REVISES FSM/NRPF GUIDANCE, PUBLISHES NEW HIGH-NEEDS DATA

■ **Yesterday's DfE Update for academies revises how schools check free school meal eligibility for families with no recourse to public funds, and publishes fresh high-needs figures.** The 7 October update sets out revised guidance on free school meals for children in families with no recourse to public funds, publishes spring 2026 census figures for high-needs pupils in special schools and free schools, and opens the 2027/28 high-needs place-change process for local authorities. It also confirms the autumn census FSM eligibility recheck deadline has moved from 1 October to 2 November. ([GOV.UK - DfE Update \(academies\), 7 October 2026](#))

→ **For your school:** Worth flagging to your FSM/pastoral team given the moved deadline, and feeding into any high-needs place-planning conversations with the LA.

■ FUNDING: PUPIL PREMIUM QUARTER 2 LANDS WITH ACADEMIES TODAY

■ **Academies open at 1 April 2026 are paid today's quarter 2 instalment of 2026/27 pupil premium funding.** Trusts can now download their quarter 2 allocation statements via DfE Sign-in; the next instalment, for academies open at 1 September 2026, follows on 11 January 2027. Maintained schools were paid on 30 September. ([GOV.UK - Pupil premium: conditions of grant 2026 to 2027](#))

■ SOUTH YORKSHIRE: DONCASTER CATHOLIC PRIMARIES SEEK ACADEMY CONVERSION

- **DfE's Yorkshire & Humber office lists two Doncaster Catholic primaries among this month's academy conversion decisions.** St Joseph and St Teresa's Catholic Primary School, and Our Lady of Perpetual Help Catholic Primary School, have applied to convert to academy status and join St Francis Catholic Multi Academy Trust, with a decision due this month. ([GOV.UK - Regions Group school decisions: Yorkshire and the Humber](#))

JARGON-BUSTER - NRPF

Cropping up in this week's DfE update:

No Recourse to Public Funds - families, often with insecure immigration status, who can't claim most mainstream benefits. They have a separate route into free school meals with its own income thresholds, which DfE revised this week.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

■ SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy

Source	Type	What we track
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.